Fernando Saenz Aguilar

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LinkedIn • GitHub • Research website

Economics graduate and Senior Research Associate at J-PAL LAC with interests in development economics, human capital, and nutrition. Experience supporting randomized controlled trials (RCTs), including survey design, power calculations, fieldwork coordination, and data quality monitoring, alongside quantitative analysis using Stata and R.

Education

Rafael Landívar University — B.A. in Business Economics 2021–2025

Grade: 98.0/100. Guatemala City, Guatemala. [Link to transcripts]

Georgia College & State University — Global UGRAD exchange Aug–Nov 2024

GPA: 4.0. Milledgeville, Georgia, USA. [Link to transcripts]

Deusto Business School — Innovation and Sustainability: Keys of Competitiveness 2023

Grade: 9.3/10. Bilbao, Spain. [Link to transcripts]

San Carlos University — Supplementary coursework, School of Engineering 2021–2023

Concurrent with undergraduate studies; coursework in calculus, linear algebra, differential equations, numerical methods, physics, and statistics. [Link to transcripts]

Research experience

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL LAC) Feb 2026–Present

Senior Research Associate | Guatemala City

Main project | PI: Karen Macours

Economic, Cultural and Taste-based Constraints to the Scaling of Climate-resilient Biofortified Maize among Diverse Smallholder Populations in Guatemala

- Supported revisions to informed-consent materials and ethics protocols in response to UVG's IRB; drafted and revised the survey instrument in XLSForm and supported enumerator training and piloting.
- Implemented daily high-frequency data quality checks across two collection rounds and provided ongoing feedback to the survey firm; reproduced and updated analysis tables with newly collected data.
- Interviewed farmers about harvest timing to inform planning for the second data collection round.
- Coordinated maize sample receipt and processing with Semilla Nueva; designed and supervised procedures to preserve blinding during nutritional laboratory analysis.
- Drafted contracts between the survey firm and host university, tracked project expenditure, and estimated field-material costs.

Cross-project Support to the J-PAL LAC Research Vertical

Early childhood development "Acompañame a Crecer" | PI: Pamela Jervis

- Worked on projections of the population aged 0–4 using Guatemala's latest available census; developed clustering rules aligned with the Ministry of Education's implementation plan.
- Designed geographic buffers to reduce control-group contamination; estimated intraclass correlation benchmarks and conducted power calculations for a pilot evaluation of the national ECD program.

Women's empowerment "Beca Artesano" | PI: Patricio Dalton

- Monitored endline fieldwork and coordinated three focus groups with the Ministry of Social Development, the survey firm, and local authorities.
- Supported reports and presentations for Ministry of Social Development teams.

Weather-triggered automatic cash transfers "Bono Emergencia" | PI: Esther Duflo

- Supported the drafting of funding proposals for competitive international research grants.

Research experience (continued)

Association of Research and Social Studies (ASIES Guatemala) Mar 2025–Feb 2026

Research Assistant | Guatemala City

- **Policy continuity in Guatemala:** Reviewed literature on policy persistence and volatility in Latin America; sourced and harmonized budget allocations and program transfers; designed descriptive time-series diagnostics.
- **Remittances and development:** Designed surveys and interview guides for three communities, analyzed household surveys and administrative records, and co-authored the final report on remittances and the agri-food sector.
- **Circular economy:** Participated in stakeholder interviews, reviewed international evidence, and contributed to the final report and responses to peer-review comments.
- **Financial inclusion consultancy:** Compiled municipal-level census and household survey data, synthesized evidence on rural development, and designed a difference-in-differences evaluation framework.

National Institute of Statistics (INE Guatemala) May–Jul 2024

Data Analyst | Guatemala City

- Developed two algorithms to detect and manage Consumer Price Index sample outliers using Tukey and median-quartile methods, following IMF and ILO guidance.
- Built three iterations of a Shiny dashboard for enumerator tasks and daily progress; analyzed quarterly source and item coverage to improve sample distribution throughout the year.

Additional analytical experience

Zona Trading Mar 2023–Apr 2024

Macroeconomics & Financial Analyst | Guatemala City

- Developed an automated economic and financial dashboard with GARCH forecasts for monthly client presentations; authored five quarterly macroeconomic and U.S. equity-market reports.

Teaching

Rafael Landívar University — Teaching Assistant

History of Economic Thought (Fall 2026); Game Theory (Spring 2026).

IGER — Volunteer Teacher Jul 2023–Sep 2025

Taught accounting, management, and basic statistics to 10th- and 11th-grade low-income students completing high school.

Coursework Certifications

MIT — Micromasters in Data, Economics, and Design of Policy 2025–2026

Foundations of Development Policy (97/100); Designing and Running Randomized Evaluations (95/100);
Data Analysis for Social Scientists (88/100); Political Economy & Economic Development (87/100);
Microeconomics (Enrolled Fall 2026). [Link to transcripts]

Ecomienza — Basic Tools for Applied Economic Research Jul–Aug 2025

EconThaki, J-PAL LAC, and IPA.

University of Zürich — Global Policy Analysis: Poverty, Development, Growth Feb–May 2025

Passive remote student; course by Dina Pomeranz.

World Bank Institute for Economic Development Mar–Apr 2025

Introduction to Behavioral Science in Public Policy; Reproducible Research Fundamentals.

Technical skills and languages

Programming: R and Stata (advanced); Python (intermediate); SQL (beginner).

Visualization and analysis: Power BI and Tableau (advanced); SPSS (beginner).

Survey platforms: SurveyCTO, ODK, and LimeSurvey (advanced).

Languages: Spanish (native); English (advanced); French (beginner).

Soft skills: Fieldwork coordination, stakeholder management, teamwork, leadership, critical thinking, academic writing, professional communication, and public speaking.

Working papers

Work in progress / Writing Sample

Sáenz, F., Milian, A., & Velásquez, J. Doomed to Poverty? Empirical Evidence from Guatemala's Income Dynamics 2016–2024.

[English PDF] [Code and materials]

Published

Sáenz, F. (2026). Technical efficiency in the use of biomass, fossil fuels, and minerals by Guatemala's productive sectors: A stochastic frontier analysis. *Undergraduate Thesis*.

[Published, Spanish]

Sáenz, F., & Mérida, R. (2026). The Effect of Human Capital Loss during COVID-19 on Youth Labor Market Outcomes in Guatemala. *Revista ECO*, 33, 39–70.

[Published article, Spanish] [English PDF] [Code and materials]

Herrera, O., Sáenz, F., Ipiña, E., & Jurado, J. (2024). Evaluation of the impact of remittances: Theoretical perspectives and SARIMA projection for Guatemala. *Landívar Economics*, 2(04), 37–58.

[Published article, Spanish]

Awards and scholarships

- **Landívar Researchers Fund (FIL), 2025:** Q4,000 grant (approx. USD 525) supporting undergraduate thesis research.
- **Magis Award, 2023–2025:** Highest GPA in the Business Economics program for three consecutive years.
- **Matrícula de Honor, 2024:** Highest 2023 GPA in the School of Business and Economic Sciences; 50% scholarship for the 2024 academic year.
- **BANGUAT / Guatemalan Economic Researchers Seminar, 2024:** Finalist for research on remittances and SARIMA projections, subsequently published in *Landívar Economics*.
- **VII Undergraduate Research Seminar, 2025:** Finalist, "Water Law in Guatemala: A Game Theory Framework."
- **V Undergraduate Research Seminar, 2024:** Finalist for research on remittances and SARIMA projections.
- **IV Undergraduate Research Seminar, 2023:** Finalist for papers on communications demonopolization and the Foreign Affairs Ministry's 2024 budget project.

Academic events and participation

EconTalk: My journey in Economics, from University to Research

Rafael Landívar Congress of Economics, Guatemala City, September 8, 2026.

Environmental & Economic Sustainability: Prospects and Challenges

Rafael Landívar 10th Scientific Week, Guatemala City, September 29, 2025.

HISA Youth Fellowship — Partially funded delegate

Headway Institute of Strategic Alliance, Oxford, August 23–26, 2025.